

Submission Process

1. Where do I submit my project?

Open the event page, go to your Team dashboard for the Congress event, and click Submission. All submission fields, link validation, and lock controls live on that page. Only the team leader can submit and lock.

2. What are the submission phases?

There are two phases: Preliminary Submission (mid-November 2026) and Final Submission (24:00 BST on 24 December 2026, 48 hours before Congress Day). Each phase has its own deadline, required fields and lock state.

3. What is the state machine for a submission?

A submission moves through Draft → Submitted → Locked. Locked happens automatically at the phase deadline. Admins can unlock with a reason for legitimate cases; every unlock is logged in the audit trail.

4. When does the Preliminary Submission open?

The Preliminary Submission window opens on 1 November 2026 and closes at 23:59 BST on 20 November 2026. Teams that miss preliminary cannot enter Final Judging.

5. When is the Final Submission deadline?

24:00 BST on Thursday, 24 December 2026 — exactly 48 hours before Congress Day. The system locks all submissions server-side at this time.

6. What time zone are deadlines in?

All deadlines are in Bangladesh Standard Time (BST, UTC+6). The platform displays your local time alongside BST wherever a deadline is shown, so there is no ambiguity.

7. Is there a grace period after the deadline?

No automatic grace period. Server-side locking happens at the exact deadline. Late submissions are only accepted with organiser approval in the case of a documented platform outage.

8. What happens if I miss the deadline?

If your submission is still in Draft when the deadline hits, it is locked as Draft, marked Incomplete and is not eligible for judging or ranking. Late requests are rarely granted.

9. Who can submit and lock the submission?

Only the team leader can click Submit and Lock. All other team members can edit fields in Draft state and see the full submission, but cannot submit.

10. Can we edit the submission after clicking Submit?

Yes, until the phase deadline. Submitting moves the state to Submitted, but the leader can revert to Draft, edit and resubmit any number of times before deadline. After deadline, the submission is Locked.

11. Can admins unlock a submission after deadline?

Yes, but only for legitimate reasons (documented platform outage, force-majeure, or admin discretion). Every unlock is logged with the admin, timestamp and reason.

12. What are the mandatory fields for Preliminary Submission?

Project name, one-line pitch, chosen domain, chosen challenge, structured problem statement, proposed solution, target user, prototype link or repo, team roles and initial mentor engagement notes. Video is optional at preliminary.

13. What are the mandatory fields for Final Submission?

Everything from Preliminary plus: a working demo link, GitHub repository link, public/unlisted YouTube demo (mandatory, playable, with thumbnail), tooling and IDE disclosure, MCP usage disclosure, prompt library, and Data & AI provenance section.

14. What common mistakes should I avoid?

Skipping the problem statement, uploading private/restricted links without a judge access note, submitting a YouTube link that is set to Private, not filling the prompt library, forgetting to disclose MCP or tooling usage, and leaving the demo link broken at deadline.

15. What are the required sections of the submission?

1) Basics 2) Problem Statement 3) Solution 4) Demo & Links 5) Data & AI Provenance 6) Tooling + IDE + memory/context files disclosure 7) MCP usage disclosure 8) Prompt Library.

16. What goes in the Basics section?

Project name, one-line pitch, chosen domain, chosen challenge (or self-defined idea title), a public summary paragraph, and the primary team language.

17. What goes in the Problem Statement?

A structured description: who the user is, what problem they face today, why existing solutions fail, and the measurable outcome your product will change.

18. What goes in the Solution section?

A structured description of your approach: the product, the AI system architecture, key features, target user journey and how it maps to the challenge's Winning Signal.

19. What are the YouTube requirements?

For Final Submission, YouTube is mandatory. The video must be Public or Unlisted (not Private), playable without login, and the platform must be able to pull the thumbnail. A submission with a failed YouTube check is marked Incomplete and non-rankable.

20. How long should the YouTube demo be?

Three to five minutes is the recommended length. Videos longer than seven minutes will only have the first seven minutes reviewed by judges.

21. What should the YouTube video show?

Problem → solution walkthrough → live demo of the working product → team introduction → call to action. Judges strongly weight seeing the product actually running with real inputs and outputs.

22. What happens if my YouTube link is Private?

Link validation will mark the video as FAIL. Because YouTube is mandatory at Final, the submission is marked Incomplete and cannot be ranked. Switch the video to Unlisted or Public and re-run the link check.

23. What are the GitHub / demo / Figma / Drive rules?

Each link is validated and marked PASS, RESTRICTED or FAIL. PASS is reachable without login. RESTRICTED means the link requires access approval — a Judge Access Note is required. FAIL is broken or unreachable and must be fixed before deadline.

24. What is a Judge Access Note?

A team-only note attached to a RESTRICTED link explaining how a judge can request access, which account to grant, and what to look for. It is visible to judges and admins but not to other participants.

25. When are links validated?

Links are validated when you add them and re-validated automatically each night until the deadline. You can also re-run validation manually from the submission page.

26. What does PASS mean on a link?

PASS means the link resolved successfully and the platform could see the content without needing login or approval. It is the safest status for any judge-critical link.

27. What does RESTRICTED mean on a link?

RESTRICTED means the link resolved but requires access approval or login to view the content. You must add a Judge Access Note explaining how a judge can request access and what account to grant.

28. What does FAIL mean on a link?

FAIL means the link is broken, mistyped or unreachable. FAIL links block the submission from being marked complete. Fix or replace the link and re-run validation.

29. What is the Data & AI provenance section?

It documents which datasets you used, whether they are public/licensed/proprietary, how you handled personal data, and which foundation models you called. This is scored under 'AI & Data Use' in the rubric.

30. What is the tooling and IDE disclosure?

A list of the IDEs (e.g. Cursor, Windsurf, Zed, VS Code), coding assistants (Copilot, Cody, Continue), token-optimisation tools (Caveman, Codeburn), and any memory/context files or 'rules' files used during the build.

31. What are 'memory/context files' and why do I disclose them?

These are files like .cursorrules, CLAUDE.md, .rules, or custom system prompts that shape the coding assistant's behaviour. Disclosure supports transparency and 'AI-native workflow' scoring.

32. What is MCP usage disclosure?

MCP (Model Context Protocol) lets AI agents call external tools. If your build uses MCP servers or acts as an MCP client, list which servers, why they were used and what tools they exposed. This affects AgentOps/architecture scoring.

33. What is the Prompt Library?

A curated list of the prompts that shaped your product — for coding, agent behaviour, evaluation and end-user features. Each prompt has a purpose, an output summary and a proprietary toggle. It demonstrates AI-native craft.

34. Do I have to expose my proprietary prompts?

No. Each prompt has a proprietary toggle. Proprietary prompts are visible to judges and admins only, never to other participants or in exports. Non-proprietary prompts may be shared publicly.

35. What are the field visibility levels?

Public (visible to everyone), Team-only (visible to your team only), Judge+Admin (judges and admins only), Admin-only (organisers only). Each field has a default level that the admin can override with a logged reason.

36. What is Public by default?

Project name, one-line pitch, public summary, chosen domain and challenge, and the YouTube link plus its thumbnail. Everything else defaults to Team-only or Judge+Admin.

37. What is Team-only by default?

The Prompt Library entries (unless the team makes them public), MCP details, tooling memory/context files, and any Judge Access Notes attached to RESTRICTED links.

38. What is Judge+Admin by default?

The full submission including everything above plus the structured problem statement, solution architecture, Data & AI provenance and tooling disclosures needed for scoring.

39. What is Admin-only by default?

Compliance flags, disqualification notes, admin discussion, override reasons and audit metadata.

40. Can other teams see our full submission?

No. Non-team participants only see the Public fields — project name, pitch, public summary, domain/challenge and the YouTube video. All other fields are hidden from other teams by API, UI, search and exports.

41. How do I know my submission is complete?

The submission page shows a live checklist. When every mandatory field is filled, all links are PASS or RESTRICTED-with-note, and the YouTube check passes, the Submit button becomes active and the state can move from Draft to Submitted.

42. What makes a submission Incomplete and non-rankable?

Missing any mandatory field, a FAIL on the YouTube link at Final, a FAIL on any mandatory link, or team size below 3 at deadline. Incomplete submissions are excluded from all rankings.

43. What validation errors will block Submit?

Empty mandatory fields, invalid URLs, links returning FAIL, YouTube marked Private, missing Judge Access Note on a RESTRICTED link, prompt library empty at Final, and MCP disclosure missing when MCP was declared.

44. Can we save progress and come back later?

Yes. All fields autosave to Draft state as you type. Any team member can edit and save. Only the team leader can move the state from Draft to Submitted.

45. Can we submit both a company (I2U) and a prompt (Z2L)?

Yes. The two competitions have separate submission surfaces. Idea to Unicorn is a team submission on the team page. Zero to Launch is an individual submission created on Congress Day.

46. How do I submit Zero to Launch?

On Congress Day, the Zero to Launch console opens at your assigned time. You receive 5 unique challenges, pick one, submit ONE prompt to your chosen approved tool, capture the output, and submit the required application sections before the countdown hits zero.

47. What is the 'One Prompt Only' rule in Zero to Launch?

You must generate your Zero to Launch product from exactly one prompt to one approved tool. Follow-up prompts, edits, or human retouching after the first prompt disqualify the submission. This is enforced by proctors and by tool logs.

48. What tools are approved for Zero to Launch?

The approved list is published on the event page a week before Congress Day. It typically includes the leading general-purpose builder tools that expose a single-prompt product generation flow.

49. What sections must the Zero to Launch submission contain?

Prompt used (verbatim), tool used, generated product link (must be public), one-minute walkthrough video, and the three-category self-assessment (Prompt Quality, Usability, Documentation & Governance).

50. What if my link is blocked by a corporate firewall the judges use?

Add a Judge Access Note describing an alternative access path (mirror URL, exported PDF, or an unblocked host). The admin can also request that IT whitelist your host for the judging window.

51. Can I include screenshots or slides in the submission?

Yes. You can attach a slide deck via a link (Google Slides, Figma slides, PDF on Drive). The deck must be accessible under the same PASS/RESTRICTED rules as any other link.

52. Can we upload files directly to the platform?

No. The platform does not host files or code — everything is submitted as a link to your preferred hosting (GitHub, Drive, Figma, YouTube, etc.). This keeps your IP under your control.

53. How do we handle sensitive personal data in the demo?

Never use real personal data in the public demo. Use synthetic or anonymised data. Disclose the data source and anonymisation approach in the Data & AI provenance section.

54. How does judging use our submission?

Assigned judges review the full submission (Judge+Admin view), score each rubric criterion (0–10), leave comments, and lock their score. Aggregation runs automatically to produce a ranked leaderboard per phase, domain and (optionally) challenge.

55. Will judges contact us for clarification?

Usually no — judging is based on the submission as it stands. In rare cases a judge lead may request a clarification via the platform. Never share contact details or attempt to reach a judge outside the platform (grounds for disqualification).

56. What happens after the Final Submission deadline?

Server-side lock triggers automatically. Judges are assigned within 24 hours, the judging window runs 25–26 December, aggregation and tie-breaking finish on the morning of Congress Day, and results are announced during the awards session on Congress Day evening.

57. Can we improve our product after submission?

You can keep working on the product itself, but only what is captured in the Locked submission is judged. Judges evaluate the version at deadline, not any post-deadline improvements.

58. How are ties broken in the leaderboard?

In this order: higher average Impact sub-score, then higher average Technical sub-score, then higher average AI & Data sub-score, then earlier submission timestamp, then admin manual resolution (with a written audit note).

59. What is the 'variance flag' on scores?

If the highest and lowest judge totals differ by 25+ points and at least three judges scored, the submission is flagged 'High Variance'. An additional judge may be assigned, and with 4+ judges a trimmed mean (drop highest and lowest, average the rest) is used.

60. Can we appeal a judging outcome?

You can raise a formal review request within 48 hours of results being published. Reviews are handled by the appeals panel and are limited to procedural questions (missing judges, calculation errors, rubric misapplication) — not disagreement with subjective scores.

61. Can we withdraw our submission after locking?

Yes. The team leader can request withdrawal at any time. Withdrawn submissions are removed from judging and ranking, and this is recorded in the audit trail.

62. How do we export our submission for our records?

From the submission page, use 'Export as PDF' to download a redacted PDF of your submission. Proprietary fields are included in the team leader's copy and redacted from public exports.

Summary

1. Submission Phases & Deadlines

- **Strict Timelines:** There are two phases: Preliminary (mid-November 2026) and Final (24:00 BST on 24 December 2026).
- **Auto-Locking:** Submissions are automatically locked server-side at the exact deadline. There are no grace periods.
- **Role Restrictions:** Only the team leader can submit, revert to draft, and lock the final submission, though all members can edit during the draft phase.

2. Mandatory Final Submission Requirements

- **Core Components:** You must include a structured problem statement, solution architecture, a working demo link, a GitHub repository link, and a YouTube demo video.
- **Disclosures:** Teams must fully disclose their Tooling & IDE usage (including memory/context files), MCP (Model Context Protocol) usage, and a Data & AI provenance section.

- **Prompt Library:** A curated list of prompts used to build the product must be submitted. You can toggle specific prompts as "Proprietary" so only judges and admins can see them.

3. YouTube Demo Rules

- **Accessibility:** The video must be set to Public or Unlisted. Private videos will fail validation and render the submission incomplete.
- **Content & Length:** The video should be 3-5 minutes (judges will only watch the first 7 minutes). It must show a walkthrough and a live demonstration of the product working with real inputs and outputs.

4. Link Validation & Access

- **Automated Checks:** All submitted links (GitHub, Figma, Drive, etc.) are validated continuously. They must return a **PASS** or **RESTRICTED** status.
- **Judge Access Notes:** If a link is RESTRICTED (requires a login or permission), you must include a Judge Access Note explaining exactly how judges can get access. **FAIL** (broken) links will block you from submitting.

5. Data Privacy & Integrity

- **No Real Personal Data:** Demos must strictly use synthetic or anonymized data. Using real sensitive personal data is prohibited.
- **Version Lock:** Judges will only evaluate the exact version of the product and repository that was locked at the deadline. Post-deadline updates will not be judged.

6. Zero to Launch (Z2L) Competition

- **Standalone Track:** This is an individual event on Congress Day, separate from the team-based Idea to Unicorn (I2U) competition.
- **One Prompt Only Rule:** Participants must generate their product using exactly *one prompt* in an approved tool. Any follow-up prompting or human editing will result in disqualification.

7. Judging & Leaderboard Mechanics

- **Scoring Visibility:** Non-team members can only see public fields (project name, pitch, YouTube video). Full details are restricted to judges and admins.
- **Tie-Breaking:** Ties on the leaderboard are broken in a specific order: Impact score, Technical score, AI & Data score, and finally, the earliest submission timestamp.
- **Appeals:** Teams can appeal within 48 hours of results, but only for procedural errors (e.g., calculation mistakes), not for disagreements with subjective judge scores.